

Realistic exit timelines

Bundle Academy · Core path · Level 2 · 3 min · Source document for NotebookLM video generation

Acquisitions, IPOs, failures and zombies: when private investments actually return money.

WHAT THIS VIDEO MUST LAND

By the end the viewer should be able to state the argument below in their own words. It is one argument, not a list of tips. Every number is illustrative of published ranges, not a forecast of any specific investment.

- Expect paper value to dip before it rises: the J-curve.
- Most exits land between years four and nine.
- Most acquisitions are modest; the giant ones are rare.
- Pace your investing across years to spread vintage risk.

THE ARGUMENT, IN ORDER

1 The J-curve is real

Narration: Paper value usually falls before it rises. Early write-offs land years before the winners are marked up.

On screen: A curve over time. Shape matters more than precise values.

Hold: about 7 seconds

2 When money actually comes back

Narration: Acquisitions cluster around years five to eight. Anything returning capital inside three years is the exception, not the plan.

On screen: A bar chart measured in % of exits in this window: Years 1 to 3 = 8 % of exits in this window; Years 4 to 6 = 34 % of exits in this window; Years 7 to 9 = 38 % of exits in this window; Year 10+ = 20 % of exits in this window.

Hold: about 8 seconds

3 What the exit looks like

Narration: Most acquisitions are modest. Life-changing outcomes exist but they are the thin end of a very long tail.

On screen: A bar chart measured in % of acquisitions: Under £25m = 46 % of acquisitions; £25m to £100m = 32 % of acquisitions; £100m to £500m = 16 % of acquisitions; Over £500m = 6 % of acquisitions.

Hold: about 8 seconds

4 Plan the pacing, not the payday

Narration: Investing steadily across years spreads you over vintages, so your outcomes are not decided by one market cycle.

On screen: A timeline visual.

Hold: about 7 seconds

5 The number to hold on to

Narration: Roughly seven years from cheque to cash, on the deals that work at all.

On screen: A stat visual.

Hold: about 6 seconds

THE SAME ARGUMENT IN PROSE

Private portfolios follow a J-curve. Early on, the failures are recognised long before the winners are re-marked, so the paper value of a young portfolio typically dips before it climbs.

Exits cluster later than most people expect. The bulk of acquisitions land somewhere between years four and nine from investment. Returns inside three years happen, but building a plan around them is building a plan around the exception.

The size distribution matters as much as the timing. Most acquisitions are modest, which is fine if your position sizing assumed it. The enormous outcomes are real but rare, and they are exactly why breadth matters.

The practical answer is pacing. Investing a steady amount each year, rather than deploying everything into one vintage, spreads you across market cycles and means your first exits start recycling into later positions.

STONE AND CONSTRAINTS

- **Never give advice.** Describe how the asset class behaves. Do not tell the viewer what to buy, how much to invest, or that anything is a good opportunity. No "you should", no "we recommend".
- **Do not invent numbers.** Use only the figures in this document. If a figure is not here, leave it out rather than estimating one.
- **Keep the risk honest.** Losing everything is the single most likely outcome for any one early-stage company. Never soften that, and never end on a purely upbeat note that contradicts it.
- **Plain English.** UK spelling. Expand any term the first time it appears. No hype words: no "unlock", "supercharge", "game-changing", "revolutionary".
- **Calm, factual delivery.** This is an explainer, not a pitch. No urgency, no countdowns, no scarcity.
- **No specific companies.** Do not name real companies as examples, and do not imply any listing is available or recommended.

BASIS OF THE FIGURES

Illustrative distributions based on published exit data. Individual outcomes vary enormously.

Bundle is an aggregator of private-market opportunities listed on third-party venues. It holds no client money, executes no trades and gives no advice. Private-market investments are illiquid, are not covered by the FSCS, and you may lose all the money you invest. This document is educational source material, not a financial promotion.